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MANDAR DEODHAR

SLIPPERY SLOPE (From top) UP's Yogi Adityanath with Smriti Irani in Amethi; Union home minister Amit Shah with Haryana CM Nayab Saini (right) and ex-CM M.L. Khattar; Maharashtra deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis offers to quit, Jun. 5

Vasundhara Raje, while picking his name in a draw of lots. Unable to control factional tiffs, Sharma has demonstrated not only his inefficiency but the very folly of his anointment.

When Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal claimed dramatically during the campaign that the BJP may replace UP's Yogi Adityanath after the Lok Sabha polls, it dug nails into already raw skin—seeking to create confusion among the cadre and Yogi's loyalists. A section of the party in UP grudges how Yogi was not used to full potential in the campaign, and that many of his recommendations were overruled.

These murmurs from its old base are becoming louder, with both cadre and veteran leaders calling it a symptom of too much concentration of power. As further proof, they point to lightweights who fill the ranks of crucial party bodies like the parliamentary board and election committee—people with no established electoral history or mass base, token figures with no bearing on decision-making. Even feedback did not elicit course correction: the BJP leadership didn't heed well-meaning suggestions from its own ground, preferring instead the laptop wisdom of hired professional agencies and their executives.

The centralisation of decision-making was such that even several CMs and state unit chiefs are cribbing that their feedback on local anti-incumbency against MPs was disregarded. Says a senior BJP leader, "An empowered and enthusiastic cadre is needed to counter narratives at the grassroots, and to bring both loyal and potential voters to polling booths." As it happened, Modi's war cry of "*char sau paar*" proved to be counterproductive and costly, with an already resentful cadre taking it too seriously and easing off during the campaign.

VOTER ALIENATION

To that process of internal enfeebling, add the estrangement of the BJP's natural voter: angry Jats all over the Green Revolution belt; irate Rajputs in UP, Rajasthan and Gujarat; restive Marathas; dejected youth all across low-growth states like UP and Bihar. They